

The California Seed Starting Cheat Sheet

Starting from seed is cheap, and it opens the door to varieties you will never find as transplants. The whole trick is getting the timing and the light right. Do those two things and the rest follows.

Start indoors or sow direct?

- **Start indoors:** tomatoes, peppers, eggplant, and brassicas (broccoli, cabbage, kale) get a head start where nights stay cool.
- **Direct sow:** beans, peas, carrots, beets, radish, and the squash family resent transplanting and grow faster sown in place.
- **Either way:** lettuce and greens do fine started indoors or sown direct. Pick whichever fits your space.
- **Transplant-shy roots:** carrots, beets, and radish are best direct sown so the taproot is never disturbed.

Sow depth and timing at a glance

Crop	Sow depth	Days to sprout	Indoors before transplant
Tomato	1/4 in	5 to 10 days	6 to 8 weeks
Pepper	1/4 in	8 to 14 days	8 to 10 weeks
Lettuce	1/8 in (surface)	5 to 10 days	4 to 6 weeks
Bean	1 to 1.5 in	7 to 10 days	Direct sow
Squash	1 in	5 to 10 days	3 to 4 weeks or direct

General rule: sow about twice as deep as the seed is wide. Cool soil slows every one of these.

Light and warmth

- Seedlings need strong light within a few inches of the leaves, or they stretch and get leggy.
- Bottom heat around 70 to 75 F speeds warm-season germination like tomatoes and peppers.
- A sunny window is usually not enough light. A simple shop light or grow light beats it.

Water and damping off

- Keep the mix moist, not soggy. Overwatering invites trouble.
- Give seedlings airflow. A small fan helps the stems toughen up.
- Use clean containers and a sterile seed-starting mix to avoid damping off, the fungus that topples young seedlings.

Coastal-California timing

- Mild winters let you start cool-season crops twice: in late summer or fall, and again in late winter.
- Start warm-season seeds indoors from late winter to early spring so plants are ready when it warms.
- Harden off over 7 to 10 days before transplanting, giving a little more outdoor time each day.
- Coastal nights stay cool, so do not rush warm-season transplants out. Wait until the nights settle.

Top three beginner mistakes

1. Not enough light, which gives you tall, floppy, leggy seedlings.
2. Starting too early, so plants outgrow their pots before it is warm enough to plant out.
3. Skipping hardening off, which shocks tender seedlings the moment they hit the garden.

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